

## Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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### Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

*Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics*

*May 2026 (expected)*

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

*M.S. in Applied Economics*

*2019*

*M.A. in Public Policy*

*2019*

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

*B.A. in Economics*

*2012*

### Fields of Interest

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics; Public Policy; Firms

### Citizenship and U.S. work authorization

Mexican citizen with U.S. permanent residency

### Working papers

**Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)**

*with David J. Henning*

We provide causal evidence that digital receipts—SMS messages reporting milk deliveries—can improve accountability, delivery behavior, and product quality in agricultural markets with limited monitoring and weak enforcement mechanisms. In a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we find that treated farmers, particularly those who self-deliver, are significantly more likely to deliver milk. This increase in delivery activity occurs without a change in average volumes delivered, suggesting a shift along the extensive margin. The intervention also improves milk quality: treated farmers deliver higher-quality (less diluted) milk. Among farmers who rely on transporters, digital receipts increase the likelihood of detecting discrepancies, switching baseline transporters, and reporting lower trust in intermediaries. These results show that the intervention works differently depending on whether information frictions are present: for self-deliverers, who already have full observability over their deliveries, impacts are concentrated on participation, while for transporter users, where observability is limited, impacts are concentrated on detecting discrepancies and moving away from dishonest transporters. By turning unobservable transactions into verifiable digital records, SMS receipts enhance transparency and make intermediary behavior more observable. Overall, our findings show how simple digital tools can reduce information frictions, shift farmer and intermediary behavior, and improve product quality in fragmented agricultural systems.

### Work in progress

**Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico**

*with Xiaofei Wang*

**Aligning Incentives through Digital Monitoring: Evidence from the Ugandan Dairy Sector**

**From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico**

## Research Grants

|                                                                                                                                                              |      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD<br><i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning and Erick Molina Perez</i> | 2025 |
| International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP<br><i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>                                           | 2024 |
| The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD<br><i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>                        | 2023 |
| J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD<br><i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>                      | 2023 |
| International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP<br><i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>                                           | 2022 |
| <b>Total external funding raised as PI: \$151,000 USD</b>                                                                                                    |      |

## Honors and Awards

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| AAE Conference Presentation Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$600 USD                      | 2025        |
| AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA)                             | 2025        |
| Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison | 2024        |
| AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD                       | 2024        |
| Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison.                  | 2023        |
| UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison                               | 2022        |
| Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison                               | 2021 – 2022 |
| Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor.           | 2019        |
| Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor                                 | 2017        |
| Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor                               | 2017        |

## Research Experience

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin   Madison, Wisconsin<br><i>Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham</i>                                     | 2021 – Present |
| Research Assistant, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan<br><i>Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown</i>                                                          | Spring 2020    |
| Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan<br><i>Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir</i> | Fall 2019      |
| Research Assistant, Northwestern University   Chicago, Illinois<br><i>Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta</i>                                                | Summer 2019    |
| Research Associate, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan<br><i>Economic Growth Institute</i>                                                                                      | 2018 – 2019    |
| Research Assistant, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan<br><i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>                                           | 2017 – 2018    |
| Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action   Lilongwe, Malawi<br><i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>                                   | Summer 2017    |
| Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM)   Mexico City, Mexico<br><i>Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka</i>                                   | 2011 – 2012    |

## Professional Experience

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance   Mexico City, Mexico     | 2014 – 2016 |
| Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities   Mexico City, Mexico    | 2013 – 2014 |
| Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities   Mexico City, Mexico | 2012 – 2013 |
| Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico   Mexico City, Mexico                | 2010 – 2011 |

## Teaching Experience

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin   Madison, Wisconsin<br><i>AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas</i> | Fall 2025   |
| <i>AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition</i>                                                                                      | Spring 2022 |

Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

Spring 2019

POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations

Fall 2018

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

Spring 2018

POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models

Fall 2017

## **Pre-Doctoral Publications**

**Magaña Sáenz, P.F.** (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

## **Talks**

- 2025 AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)
- 2024 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2023 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2022 Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2021 Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

## **Affiliations**

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty, University of Wisconsin

2025 – 2026

## **Other Information**

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X (Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

## **References**

Laura Schechter  
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